



VOLUNTEER HANDBOOK
THE PLACE OF FORSYTH COUNTY, INC.
("The Place")

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VOLUNTEER HANDBOOK

Introduction

The Place is a place for hope and encouragement to support neighbors with resources to meet basic needs and achieve self-sufficiency. We serve our communities with emergency financial assistance, clothing, food, educational opportunities, plus numerous support services. Through our many initiatives and services, we are changing lives in Forsyth and Dawson counties. With your help, we will continue to make a positive impact on our community. Thank you for volunteering with us and for giving your time so generously!

The employees, volunteers, and donors of The Place are committed to working for the public good. The Place is a nonprofit organization and a wonderful organization for those who have the heart to do the work of lifting members of the community up when they need help. That's why there's a heart in our logo.

Everyone who works here—in whatever capacity—should respect the dignity and worth of all individuals and treat them with respect, courtesy, and integrity.

General Volunteer Guidelines

- Treat all visitors with respect, as though they were guests in your own home. Greet our visitors with a smile. Remember, you are representing The Place. Our goal is for our clients and customers to leave with a good impression of our work.
- Be on time. Please arrive at least five minutes before your scheduled shift so you can start your work on time.
- If you know you will be absent, contact the Volunteer Coordinator and/or program manager/coordinator as soon as possible so that we can find a replacement for you. Your presence is valuable and your contributions will be missed.
- All volunteers are entitled to take a 15-minute break during a 4-hour shift.
- Dress appropriately for the work you will be doing and please avoid extremes in dress. Flashy, skimpy, or revealing clothing is unacceptable. The Place's image can be negatively affected by donors' and clients' negative reactions to body piercing such as nose rings, eyebrow rings, and tongue piercing. Also, tattoos that may be perceived as offensive should be covered.
- Must wear closed toed shoes.

- Do not text, talk on your cell phone, listen to music, or use ear buds or headphones while at your position.
- If an uncomfortable situation or an emergency develops, contact any staff member **immediately** to oversee the situation.
- If you feel another volunteer or an employee is behaving inappropriately, doing something incorrectly, or is misinformed, let the Volunteer Coordinator or another supervisor know about the situation.

A happy customer might tell a friend, but an unhappy one
will tell the world. ~ Author unknown

Interacting with Visitors

Positive one-on-one contact with staff, clients, customers, donors, and other volunteers determines the satisfaction levels of our visitors. Therefore, we strive to make everyone on-site and at our events feel comfortable and welcome at The Place.

Please make every effort to enhance our customers' and clients' experience by:

- Treating visitors as you would want to be treated and greeting them appropriately.
- Responding to questions or seeking information from staff.
- Being mindful of what you discuss with other volunteers and staff while clients and customers are present.
- Watching your choice of words. Keep your language professional and courteous.
- Thanking guests for visiting The Place.

Volunteer Roles

Volunteers work in a variety of positions at The Place, depending on their interests and skill sets. All volunteers will be trained for their assignments by the Volunteer Coordinator or staff members before being given an assignment. We need volunteers in a variety of roles—some long-term and others for special events and programs. If you have the time and the heart to contribute your efforts to The Place, we will match you with one of the services we provide.

The Thrift Store

The community helps to support The Place by donating clothes, household items, and toys that are clean and in good condition. Volunteers sort, organize, and stock them.

Food Pantry

We have teams that help pack food items so they can be distributed to clients and other teams who meet with clients who need food.

Event Volunteers

The Place has many events throughout the year, both on-site and at other locations. We often need volunteers to help set up and break down tables, answer questions, take donation payments, serve refreshments, take photographs, and related functions. These events are critical to our fundraising efforts and additional help is essential.

People will forget what you said, people will forget
what you did, but people will never forget how
you made them feel. ~ Maya Angelou

Administrative Support

Occasionally we need help in the main office working with files, mailings, or marketing efforts.

Support for Seniors

One of The Place's missions is to enable senior citizens who qualify for our services to stay in the homes and to live as independently as possible. These seniors order food from our food pantry each week, and one of our volunteer teams delivers it to them.

All volunteers that make home visits are required to undergo a criminal background check which is performed by the Forsyth/Dawson County Sheriff's Office at no charge.

Home Repairs

We have a team of volunteers who contribute their time to doing minor home repairs such as fixing a broken fence, rebuilding a broken wheelchair ramp, etc. In addition to

these services, the volunteers are providing personal contact—conversations with people they’ve come to know and trust—which helps to keep them from feeling too isolated.

Local High Schools

We have volunteer opportunities with students in local high schools, including The Bronco’s Place, Summer Internship Program, and Orange Duffel Bag Initiative.

All volunteers that interact with minors are required to undergo a criminal background check which is performed by the Forsyth/Dawson County Sheriff’s Office at no charge.

Student Volunteers

Students may earn service hours for their time volunteering at The Place. Students who are 14-15 years old must have an adult accompanying them in order to volunteer. Students who are 16-17 years old must have a signed consent form. Students who are 18 years old are considered adults.

Client Confidentiality

The Place’s staff and volunteers cannot disclose information about clients without the client’s **written** consent. Counselors must treat as confidential the identity of, and all information about, people who contact the program. Our clients come to us for help, and we should honor them by treating their names and situations confidentially.

Gifts or Gratuities

Please do not accept any gift or gratuity of any kind from a donor or client without the express authorization of the President/CEO. Also, we ask that you refrain from giving personal gifts or direct personal assistance to clients. There may be a time when a client tells you about a specific need and you believe you can solve that problem for them. For example, a new mother may need a stroller and you may have one at home that you no longer need. Please do not tell the client that you will bring it in. Refer the person to a staff member. We do this to protect your privacy and to ensure that all our clients are treated fairly.

Harassment

We do not tolerate the harassment of anyone on our sites or at our events. This includes any form of harassment relating to an individual’s race; sexual orientation; color; religion; genetic information; national origin; gender identity; pregnancy, childbirth, or related medical conditions; age; disability or handicap; citizenship status; service member status; or any other category protected by federal, state, or local law. If you

witness harassing behavior, you are obligated to point it out, as silence in a harassment situation is equivalent to being part of the problem.

If you see harassment happening, speak up. Being harassed is terrible; having bystanders pretend they don't notice is infinitely worse. ~ Celeste Ng

If you have any questions about what constitutes harassing behavior or what conduct is prohibited by this policy, please discuss the issue with the Volunteer Coordinator. At a minimum, the term "harassment" as used in this policy includes:

- Offensive remarks, comments, jokes, slurs, or verbal conduct about some aspect of an individual.
- Offensive pictures, drawings, photographs, figurines, or other graphic images, conduct, or communications, including e-mail, faxes, and copies pertaining to an individual. Inappropriate graphic images on clothing are included as well.
- Offensive sexual remarks, sexual advances, or requests for sexual favors regardless of the gender of the individuals involved.
- Offensive physical conduct, including touching and gestures, regardless of the gender of the individuals involved.
- Symbols, slogans, or items that are associated with hate, intolerance toward any select group displayed on clothing, hats, jewelry, accessories, etc.
- Political messages of any type should not be displayed. We respect your right to support your political party and causes, but we want to avoid discord with or discomfort for our clients, donors, volunteers, and other employees during work hours and while on site.

Events

Volunteers may have the opportunity to help at The Place sponsored events.

Christmas is not as much about opening our presents as opening our hearts. ~ Janice Maeditere

Animals

Animals are not allowed in the buildings, unless they are service animals. To determine if it is a service animal, ask these two questions:

- Is the animal required because of a disability?
- What job or task has it been trained to perform?

Safety and Security

Client, employee, donor, and customer security are very important to The Place. While the primary responsibility for our safety and security resides with the staff, ensuring the safety and security of visitors, the facility, and its contents is a shared responsibility.

Be alert for situations that threaten our safety or security. Trust your instincts. If you observe something that seems suspect or peculiar, notify a staff member immediately. Do not put yourself at any personal risk.

Examples of Safety/Security Issues

While it is impossible to anticipate every situation that may represent a threat to safety or security, possibly threatening situations may include:

Anything jeopardizing the safety of the people at The Place, such as water on the floor, broken equipment, an unattended ladder, etc.

- An unattended package
- An apparent heart attack or other acute physical distress
- A lost or unattended child
- Smoke or fire
- An accident involving a guest or visitor
- A visitor in an agitated state who is attracting the attention of other guests
- The display of a weapon of any kind, including scissors or pocketknives. When in doubt, alert a staff member immediately.

Drug and Alcohol Policy

As a condition of continued volunteerism, The Place prohibits volunteers from reporting to The Place or performing their duties with **any** unlawful drugs or alcohol in their systems. It is a matter of workplace safety. Volunteers are also prohibited from using, possessing, manufacturing, distributing, or planning to distribute alcohol or drugs while at The Place; on The Place's, a donor's, or client's property (including in personal vehicles onsite); during lunch or breaks; or in The Place's vehicles. These restrictions also

apply to unlawful drugs. Further, The Place prohibits **all** unlawful drug use, possession, or distribution, whether on or off duty. Drugs can stay in one's system and affect work later.

The Place reserves the right to dismiss a volunteer from the premise where The Place has reasonable suspicion that the volunteer has violated this policy.

Tobacco and Smoking

Use of tobacco and smoking in any form, including e-cigarettes, is permitted only in designated outdoor areas at The Place. Volunteers who smoke should do so only during their break and/or at lunchtime. The smoking area is to be always kept clean. Smoking is prohibited by law where paint or other flammable materials may be present. Smoking is not allowed in company vehicles.

Protecting People and Property

Firearms

Unless otherwise prohibited by applicable law or regulation, The Place prohibits volunteers and all other persons (other than law enforcement and authorized security personnel) from having firearms in working areas, in buildings or on their person during work hours, or while performing work. Firearms are prohibited on all company property and in company vehicles. The only exception to this rule is that a "lawful weapons carrier" may keep a firearm in his or her personal vehicle as long as it is kept out of sight in a locked, enclosed compartment or area of his or her vehicle in the parking lot.

Failure to properly secure and protect a firearm or to comply with this policy may subject a volunteer to dismissal from the property.

Weapons and Dangerous Instruments

Ammunition, explosives, weapons (other than firearms), or dangerous instrumentalities of any kind are prohibited on The Place property and in our vehicles. Likewise, no volunteer should possess any ammunition, explosive, other weapon, or dangerous instrumentalities at any time while performing any work for The Place. In this context, "possess" means to have on your person, in your vehicle or any vehicle assigned to you, or in other property in your presence or under your control (such as bags, packages, purses, briefcases, desks, toolboxes, lockers, etc.), while on company premises.

Surveillance System/Cameras

The Place maintains a system of surveillance equipment with the ability to record video. Most cameras are visible on our site, particularly in the areas where cash is handled. We

do not use any type of surveillance equipment in our restrooms. The equipment is intended to protect our staff, clients, volunteers, and donors and is used in compliance with Georgia and federal laws. When you sign your statement that you have read and will comply with the policies in this handbook, you are acknowledging that you know your image may be recorded.

Reporting of Accidents and Hazards

All accidents involving donors, volunteers, or clients, including those which do not involve serious injury, must be reported immediately to a The Place staff member. Only through a full knowledge of accidents can The Place become a safer, healthier place to work for everyone.

Immediately report any unsafe conditions, defective tools or equipment, or other hazards to a The Place staff member. Each volunteer is expected to assist The Place in maintaining safe working conditions. Safety requires constant vigilance and common sense and is everyone's responsibility.

Community Service

The Place offers the opportunity to gain required hours for a received citation. This is for Court Mandated, Community Service, Pre-Trial, and Attorney Suggested. Community Service volunteers must apply via the website and include all required documents as outlined in the application – a copy of a photo ID, charge(s), or letter from an attorney listing charges and number of required community service hours.

There are certain charges that are not accepted: violent crimes, sexual misconduct, crimes involving children, and theft/shoplifting.

Revision History:

Revision	Date	Description of changes	Requested By
0	03/31/2026	Initial Release	
1.0	05/12/2026	Added Service Animal policy	Nicole Morgan
1.1	06/24/2026	General revisions/edits; Added the following sections: Drug and Alcohol Policy, Tobacco and Smoking, Protecting People and Property, Firearms, Weapons and Dangerous Instruments, Surveillance System/Cameras, Reporting of Accidents and Hazards; added Community Service section	Amber Pham